

Joint Fusion vs Replacement: How Surgeons Choose

The case for fusion in ankles, wrists and small joints.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) ·
2026-06-23 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



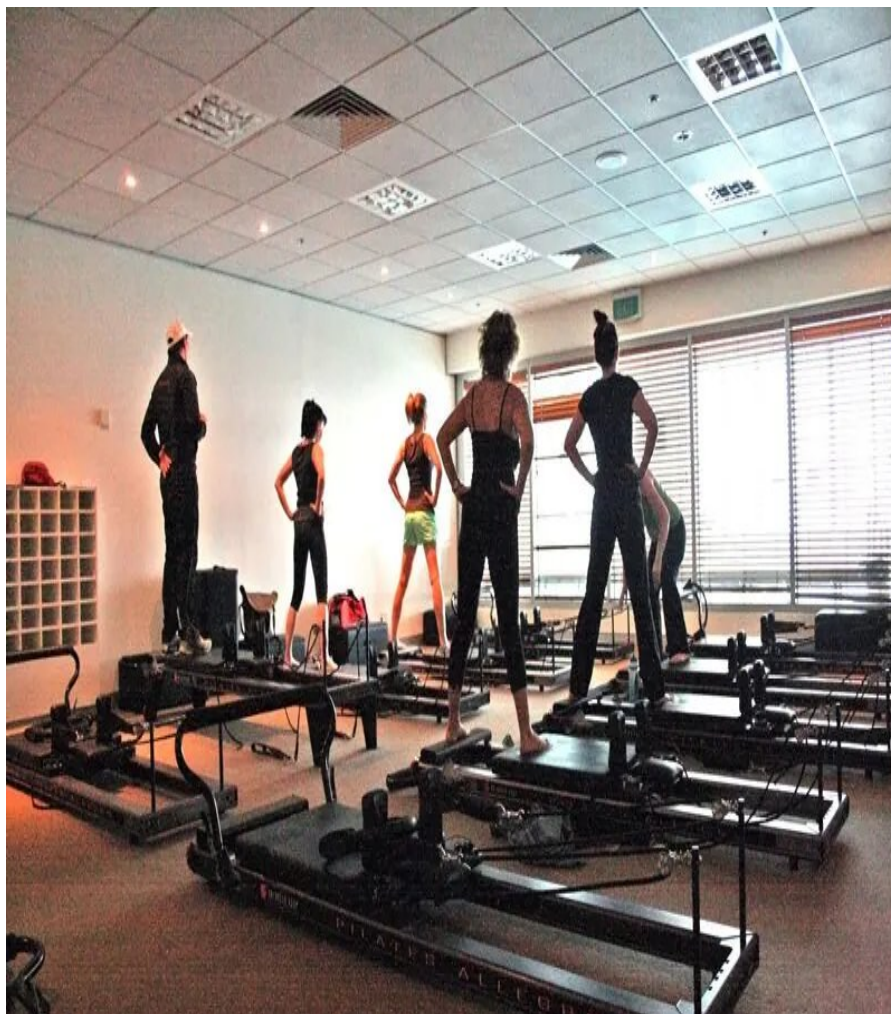
Openly licensed image via Openverse

The case for fusion in ankles, wrists and small joints.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
-

Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/exercises/ankle\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



Openly licensed image via Openverse

This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Current research consistently highlights the importance of a step-wise approach to managing arthritis, starting with non-surgical options. Randomised trials and systematic reviews show that a combination of exercise, physical therapy, and appropriate medications can significantly improve joint function and reduce pain for many people. Surgical interventions, such as joint fusion or replacement, are typically considered when these conservative treatments are no longer effective and a person's quality of life is severely impacted.

Clinical guidelines from leading medical bodies across the UK emphasise shared decision-making, where the person with arthritis and their healthcare team discuss all available options, weighing up the potential benefits and risks of each. The focus is on preserving natural joint function where possible and, when surgery is necessary, choosing the procedure most likely to offer long-term relief and improved mobility, tailored to the individual's specific circumstances and the affected joint.

For smaller joints, like those in the wrist or foot, and particularly for the ankle, fusion (arthrodesis) is often considered a reliable option for pain relief and stability, especially in specific arthritis types. Conversely, for larger, weight-bearing joints like the hip and knee, joint replacement (arthroplasty) often provides superior functional outcomes. The evidence for these preferences is built on decades of patient outcomes and ongoing surgical technique refinements.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Ignoring early symptoms:** Hoping pain will simply go away on its own. *Fix: Keep a symptom diary and discuss persistent pain with your family doctor.* **Overdoing it on good days:** Pushing through significant pain, leading to flare-ups. *Fix: Pace yourself and listen to your body, even when feeling well.* **Stopping medication without advice:** Discontinuing prescribed drugs because you feel better. *Fix: Always consult your doctor before making changes to your medication.* **Avoiding all movement:** Fearing that exercise will damage your joints further. *Fix: Engage in gentle, recommended exercises to maintain strength and flexibility.* **Self-diagnosing online and delaying professional help:** Relying solely on internet searches for treatment plans. *Fix: Seek professional medical advice for an accurate diagnosis and personalised care plan.*

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's important to reach out to your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist if you notice significant changes in your joint health. Don't wait for your next routine appointment if you experience any of the following:

* Sudden, severe increase in joint pain. * New or rapidly worsening joint swelling or redness. * Feeling generally unwell with a fever alongside joint pain. * Rapid loss of movement or function in a joint. * Joint pain that keeps you awake at night or is present at rest.

Frequently Asked Questions

What happens if I delay treatment for arthritis? Delaying effective treatment can lead to worsening joint damage and increased pain over time. Early intervention, including medication and lifestyle adjustments, can help slow the progression of the disease and preserve joint function.

How long does recovery take after joint surgery? Recovery time varies greatly depending on the type of surgery, the joint involved, and your overall health. For some, it might be a few weeks, while for more complex procedures, it could be several months of rehabilitation. Your surgical team will provide a tailored recovery plan.

Can I still be active after joint fusion or replacement? Absolutely. The goal of these surgeries is often to reduce pain and improve your ability to move. While some activities might need to be modified, many people return to a good level of activity, including walking, swimming, and cycling, following successful recovery.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about joint fusion vs replacement: how surgeons choose?

Short answer: Joint replacement is often preferred for large, weight-bearing joints like the hip and knee, aiming for improved function. Conversely, joint fusion is frequently considered for smaller joints such as those in the wrist or foot, and particularly the ankle, offering pain relief and stability. Both surgeries are typically considered when non-surgical treatments are no longer effective and quality of life is severely impacted.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk